Loose Ends — Design Breakdown

Overview

Loose Ends is a time-loop stealth mystery set during a royal wedding. The player repeatedly relives the same day to uncover a conspiracy, gather knowledge, and change the outcome for the game's characters. As Lead Game and Systems Designer, I designed the identity-switching system, clue progression, dialogue structure, and core level layout.

Mystery & Clue Progression

The central design goal was to make discovery feel active rather than automatic. Players uncover the conspiracy by combining overheard conversations, environmental clues, documents, and information revealed through different identities.

- Players begin with limited knowledge and must explore to identify suspects and motives.
- Clues are distributed across social spaces, private rooms, and character interactions.
- Knowledge gained in one loop informs the player's choices in later loops.
- The evidence board helps players connect suspects, motives, and events.

Design outcome: Players are rewarded for paying attention, revisiting areas with new knowledge, and testing how different identities change access to information.

Disguise System

The disguise system is the main player verb for accessing new narrative and spatial possibilities. By adopting different identities, the player changes how NPCs respond and which areas become available.

- Each disguise provides access to different characters, conversations, and locations.
- Identity changes alter dialogue options and can expose or hide conspiracy information.
- The system encourages experimentation: the same location can reveal new information depending on who the player is pretending to be.
- Disguises support both stealth and social deduction, allowing players to gather knowledge without direct confrontation.

Design outcome: The player's identity becomes a puzzle-solving tool, not only a way to avoid detection.

Keyword-Based Dialogue Structure

Dialogue was designed around topics and keywords rather than fixed linear conversations. Players unlock new topics by eavesdropping, finding letters, examining evidence, and discovering information across loops.

- Conversations reveal keywords that can be used with other characters.
- New knowledge opens dialogue paths that were previously unavailable.
- Topics are tied to the mystery, allowing players to test assumptions and gather targeted information.
- The structure supports replayability because earlier discoveries become useful in later loops.

Design outcome: Dialogue becomes part of the investigation system, helping players build a mental model of the conspiracy.

Level Layout & Access Design

I designed the palace layout to support exploration, social navigation, and restricted access. The layout separates public performance spaces, private rooms, service areas, and areas connected to key story reveals.

- Public areas encourage overhearing gossip and observing character relationships.
- Private rooms contain personal clues, documents, and higher-risk exploration opportunities.
- Restricted areas reinforce the value of disguises and create clear player goals.
- The layout guides players toward important narrative spaces without removing the feeling of exploration.

Design outcome: The space supports both narrative discovery and stealth-based experimentation.

Evidence Board System

The evidence board gives players a space to organise what they have learned and see connections between characters, motives, and events.

- Players collect and connect clues related to suspects and the conspiracy.

- The board makes hidden relationships more readable as the investigation progresses.
- It supports player agency by letting them decide which leads to pursue.
- It also helps communicate progress without over-explaining the mystery.

Design outcome: The system turns scattered discoveries into a clearer investigative journey.

Playtesting & Lessons Learned

Playtesting showed that players responded strongly to discovery, social information, and the ability to return to familiar spaces with new knowledge. Based on feedback, the team adjusted pacing, clarity of objectives, and the way information was presented through dialogue and environmental clues.

Key lessons:

- Players need a clear reason to revisit areas after gaining new knowledge.
- Disguises are more engaging when they change both access and dialogue options.
- Mystery information should be discoverable through multiple routes, so players do not feel stuck.
- Systems are strongest when they support the game goal: uncovering a hidden truth.

Characters

Character	Public role	Secret / motive	Relationship to Jeanne	Possible fate
Jeanne	Apparently murdered performer / former lover of the Heir	Seeks revenge against those who tried to kill her	Central victim-turned-avenger	Helps the player; may kill the Business Owner
Business Owner (BO)	Successful suitor marrying the Heir	Wants status and influence through the marriage; involved in the conspiracy	Helped arrange Jeanne's murder	Can be exposed, killed by Jeanne, or killed by chandelier
Countess	Mother of the Heir; hosts the wedding	Arranged Jeanne's murder for political gain; promoted the Baron	Main conspirator	Can be publicly exposed through leaked letters
Baron	Celebrated noble / duelist	Fake nobility, criminal past, military manipulation; helped eliminate Jeanne	Conspirator	Can be humiliated, arrested, or killed in the duel
Heir	Daughter of the Countess; reluctant bride	Loved Jeanne; unaware of the full conspiracy	Jeanne's lover	Can learn the truth; may react to the countess's exposure

Character	Public role	Secret / motive	Relationship to Jeanne	Possible fate
King	Guest of honor	Represents royal authority and public consequences	Unaware conspirator?	Witnesses' exposure/arrests
Alexander	Business Owner's automaton	Loyal enforcer	Hunts the "ring thief"	Can be redirected or avoided
Mechanist	Inventor/tool provider	Provides mechanisms and possibly information	Potential ally or information source	Enables chandelier/confetti plans

Quest breakdown

Quest 1 — Steal the Wedding Rings

Jeanne's letter directs the player to steal the wedding rings. The player uses the disguise system to access the Guest Bedroom. Stealing the rings causes the Business Owner to send Alexander away, creating an opportunity for Jeanne.

Design notes:

- The letter should hint at the disguise machine.
- The ring theft should teach the player that disguises create access.
- If the rings are stolen, Jeanne can kill the Business Owner.

Quest 2 — Learn Who Jeanne Is

The player gathers knowledge about Jeanne through gossip, servants, theatre guests, the Countess, and clues in the Heir's room. Jeanne reveals her identity and her intention.

Design notes:

- Knowledge sources: noble gossip, servants, theatre guests, Heir's room, Mechanist.
- The player should understand that Jeanne wants revenge, not merely to stop the wedding.

Quest 3 — Uncover the Conspiracy

After learning Jeanne's identity, the player investigates the conspiracy. By using disguises and overheard conversations, they discover the roles of the Business Owner, Countess, and Baron.

Design notes:

- Disguising as the Business Owner or Baron can reveal political motives.
- The player may choose whether to tell Jeanne about assassination opportunities.

Quest 4 — Execute the Revenge

The player chooses how to punish each conspirator: expose the Countess, ruin or kill the Baron, and deal with the Business Owner.

Example Gameplay Sequence

1. Loop Start — Arrive at the Wedding

The player begins the loop with limited knowledge. Their first goal is to observe the wedding, identify important characters, and find a safe way to gather information.

The player overhears guests discussing a mysterious performer, a recent murder, and tensions surrounding the marriage. These conversations introduce early keywords and suggest that several guests may be hiding something.

2. Gather Public Information

The player moves through the ballroom and theatre, listening to noble gossip. One guest mentions Jeanne, a performer connected to the Heir. Another suggests that the Baron's noble status may not be genuine.

The player records these leads on the evidence board:

- Jeanne may have been murdered.
- The Baron may have hidden connections.
- The Countess appears to benefit from the marriage.

At this stage, the player has suspicions but not proof.

3. Use a Disguise to Access a Restricted Area

The player finds an opportunity to disguise themselves as a noble. This new identity allows them to enter a more private area and speak with characters who would otherwise ignore or distrust them.

While disguised, the player asks about Jeanne. A noble reveals that Jeanne had a close relationship with the Heir, and that her death was quickly ruled an accident. This creates a new lead: the player should investigate the Heir's room.

4. Discover a Personal Clue

In the Heir's room, the player finds letters and a portrait suggesting a secret romance between Jeanne and the Heir. The letters reveal that Jeanne feared someone close to the family.

The player adds a new connection to the evidence board:

Jeanne ↔ Heir ↔ Possible family involvement

This does not yet identify the killer, but it gives the player a stronger reason to investigate the Countess, the Business Owner, and the Baron.

5. Return to Dialogue with New Knowledge

With the new keyword or knowledge gained from the letters, the player returns to a character they spoke to earlier. Because they now know about Jeanne's relationship with the Heir, they can ask more specific questions.

The character reveals that Jeanne had been threatened before her disappearance. The player now understands that her death may not have been an accident.

6. Loop End — Review and Plan

At the end of the loop, the player reviews the evidence board. They now have a clearer picture of the relationships and motives, but they still lack direct proof against the conspirators.